

US MARINE UNIFORM AND KIT

When the US Marines were first deployed in Vietnam in 1965, they were ill-equipped for an environment in which terrible heat exhausted the infantrymen and incessant rain ruined their kit and uniforms. And so, lightweight, camouflage uniforms were issued in 1966–67, replacing the heavy olive-green “Utility” unifom. The hazards of patrols and sweeps in Vietnam – where ambushes and booby-trap devices inflicted a heavy toll of casualties – meant that personal protection was of high priority, hence the wearing of flak jackets and the eventual adoption of reinforced jungle boots.

► COAT TROPICAL WR CLASS II

Date 1960s

Origin US

Material Cotton, poplin

The tight weave on this shirt made it wind-resistant and almost waterproof. The fabric was found to offer a good mix of breathability and defence against biting insects.

Camouflage pattern for tropical zones

▼ JUNGLE BOOTS

Date 1960s

Origin US

Material Leather, canvas, nylon, rubber

These tropical combat (or jungle) boots were among the most common type issued to Marines. Their hard rubber soles were directly moulded on since stitching tended to rot in the hot climate. From 1967, Panama sole boots were issued, with an embedded steel plate to protect against punji-stick booby-traps.



► M1 HELMET

Date 1960s

Origin US

Material Manganese-steel

The M1 was a slightly modified version of the famous World War II helmet. It featured a pressure clip, which was introduced to reduce the risk of choking.



Manganese-steel helmet under camouflage cover

Rope ridge to prevent slippage of weapon sling



▲ M61 WEBBING

Date 1960s

Origin US

Material Nylon

The straps of the M61 webbing looped over the Marine infantryman's shoulders to help take the weight of the equipment hung around his waistbelt.